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NUCLEAR PLANNING GROUP

EARLY COMBINED USE OF NATO
CONVENTIONAL AND NUCLEAR CAPABILITIES

Report by the Permanent Representatives

I. PURPOSE

This report discusses political as well as military aspects of an early combined use of NATO conventional and nuclear capabilities, drawing on comments by the NATO Military Authorities that deal with the military advantages and disadvantages. It should be read in conjunction with the reports(1) of the NATO Military Authorities on this subject, a large portion of whose content is not duplicated herein.

II. BACKGROUND

2. At their meeting in Mittenwald in May, 1971 the NPG Ministers discussed a paper on unresolved problems related to tactical nuclear defence written by former Secretary General Brosio(2). This paper suggested, among other matters, an examination of the possibility of an early combined use of our conventional and nuclear capabilities as soon as an enemy attack is identified as a major aggression and before our conventional forces have suffered substantial losses, and a constrained but continuing combined use if the aggressor persists in his attack(3). In a subsequent report containing suggestions for investigating the unresolved problems, the Permanent Representatives proposed(4) that the NATO Military Authorities might be requested to indicate in general terms what military advantages and disadvantages might accrue from an early combined use, noting at the same time that the question of constrained but continuing follow-on use

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- (1) NPG/D(73)8, 30th July, 1973
 - (2) PO/71/226, 10th May, 1971, hereafter referred to as PO 226
 - (3) PO 226, paragraph 7(e)
 - (4) NPG/D(71)13, 4th October, 1971, paragraph 7(c)

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could be considered at a later date when more progress had been made in the Follow-on Use Work Programme. Agreeing with this approach, the Ministers invited(1) the NATO Military Authorities to prepare a report on early combined use. Their response is contained in a document(2) consisting of a report by SHAPE(3) and related comments by the Military Committee(4).

3. In order to place the discussion of early combined use in proper perspective, it may be useful to recall the circumstances that existed at the time that PO 226 proposed examination of this subject. In early 1971, the NPG was actively continuing its investigation of the question of whether there would be a net benefit for NATO in the tactical employment of nuclear weapons(5), primarily by exploring the consequences of follow-on use, namely a NATO decision to continue the tactical use of nuclear weapons after conventional defence and an initial use of nuclear weapons by NATO had failed to achieve the objective of bringing the conflict to a satisfactory conclusion. The first three studies in the Follow-on Use Work Programme initiated by the NPG Ministers in 1969 had just become available. While fully recognising the inappropriateness of seeking to reach conclusions of a general nature on the basis of the first three studies alone, PO 226 noted their thrust seemed to be that, in a situation where NATO was inferior in conventional strength, the tactical use of nuclear weapons by both sides could worsen the military situation for NATO and lead to high civilian losses. The paper

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- (1) NPG/D(71)15, 28th October, 1971, paragraph 18(b)
 - (2) NPG/D(73)8
 - (3) SHAPE 1450.15/20-2-4/73, 15th March, 1973, with enclosure SHAPE 1450.15/20-2-4/S22/73, 15th March, 1973 circulated under cover of NPG/D(73)8. Hereafter referred to as SHAPE Report.
 - (4) MCM-47-73, 27th July, 1973, also circulated under cover of NPG/D(73)8. Hereafter referred to as MC Comments.
 - (5) Right from its inception the NPG had given much attention to this general subject. For example, at their meeting in Washington in April, 1967, the NPG Ministers stressed the importance of developing practical plans for the possible tactical use of nuclear weapons in particular circumstances in various areas in Allied Command Europe, especially since uncertainties, such as the question of possible Soviet responses, made it difficult to predict when it would be of net advantage to NATO to initiate tactical use in response to an aggression less than general war. At the same meeting, they began a study programme that led eventually to the development of the political guidelines for initial use. (PO/67/276, 20th April, 1967, Annex, paragraphs 6,8).

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concluded that the NPG should, in a quest for positive solutions, analyse the factors that contributed to the negative results that it saw in the studies. It identified some general factors for investigation, covering possible changes in force structure, improved weaponry, different concepts and tactics, and modified arrangements for political control. It was important, the paper concluded, to explore such possibilities in the search to find the basis for a credible, effective and acceptable tactical utilisation of nuclear weapons by which a potential aggressor, even with superior conventional forces, could be halted while at the same time keeping collateral damage to the civilian population within acceptable limits, that is, comparable to those of conventional warfare. The suggestions made in PO 226 were intended, among other things, to meet this need.

4. Specifically with regard to the early combined use proposal, the paper pointed out that NPG studies conducted up to that time had generally assumed a scenario in which NATO had resorted to the tactical use of nuclear weapons only after NATO had reached the point of impending conventional defeat, and long after there was no doubt that the attack was a major aggression. The paper therefore suggested looking at the possible tactical use of nuclear weapons by NATO, together with continued use of its conventional strength, at a somewhat earlier stage in the evolution of the fighting. In other words, PO 226 proposed examination of a part of the spectrum of conflict that had not yet been given full attention.

III. DISCUSSION

General Comment

5. The SHAPE Report provides an analysis of the possible military advantages and disadvantages that might accrue to NATO as a result of the early combined tactical use of conventional and nuclear weapons in Allied Command Europe (ACE). Emphasising that no attempt is made to answer the question of whether NATO should resort to such use, the SHAPE Report observes that early tactical use is envisioned within the approved strategy of flexible response and that the question of adherence to NATO strategy is not at issue(1). In this context, we note that the most recent DFC Ministerial guidance to the NATO Military Authorities states that NATO must maintain a capability for the tactical use of nuclear weapons, the primary purpose of which is to add to the deterrence of conventional attacks of any magnitude and counter them if necessary, by confronting the enemy with the prospect of consequent escalation of the conflict, and, to deter, and if necessary respond to, the tactical use of

(1) SHAPE Report, paragraph 7.

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nuclear weapons by posing the threat of escalation to all-out nuclear war. This capability should be of such a character and so deployed and organised as to present the aggressor with the clear risk that an attack on NATO at any level may escalate into the nuclear dimension, while preserving for NATO as much flexibility as possible in the exercise of that option(1). This is consistent with the statement in the Provisional Political Guidelines that a variety of situations can be envisaged in which tactical use might have to be initiated by NATO at an early stage, but that NATO should not be committed in advance to such use(2). In view of the foregoing, we concur that early combined use is one of the options open to NATO within the current strategy.

6. Although early combined use is within the current NATO strategy which embraces both major and limited aggression(3), it is clear that a NATO decision on such use would be dependent, inter alia, on the magnitude of the aggression, as the SHAPE Report intimates(4). This, of course, does not imply that NATO would have to reach a formal agreement on whether the aggression was major or limited as defined by MC 14/3 before reaching a decision on early combined use since this would unnecessarily complicate the political consultation and decision-making process.

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- (1) DPC/D(73)8, 30th May, 1973, paragraphs 18(b), 24;
see also DPC/D(67)23, 11th May, 1967, paragraphs 17, 25
and MC 14/3, 16th January, 1968, paragraphs 2, 16-18, 25,
27, 32-35
 - (2) DPC/D(69)58(Revised), 10th December, 1970, paragraph 30
 - (3) Major aggression is defined as an attack that imperils,
directly, either one or more NATO countries, to the
extent that survival as free and independent nations is
immediately at stake, or the integrity of military
forces, to the extent that capabilities essential to the
effective accomplishment of NATO strategic objectives
are imminently subject to unacceptable deterioration.
Limited aggression covers, in essence, all other forms
of military attacks (including overt incursions and
limited hostile actions) except covert actions and
infiltrations (MC 14/3, 16th January, 1968, Annex A to
Enclosure 1, paragraphs 2-7)
 - (4) SHAPE Report, paragraph 9a

7. The SHAPE Report indicates that its analysis is based on existing political guidance and reflects current ACE concepts and doctrine governing the tactical use of nuclear weapons(1). The analysis deliberately excludes consideration of political factors that would not be known before an actual situation arises but that could nevertheless have a direct impact on striking a balance of military advantages and disadvantages(2). The Report concludes, in essence, that a full and accurate assessment of this balance could only be made in the light of the particular situation that prevails at the time that early combined use might be under consideration(3). It points out, however, that an improved awareness on the part of political and military planners and decision-makers of the variable elements discussed in the Report (as well as others that might be identified in the future) would make an important contribution to the goal of deterrence and toward a viable defence of NATO in the event of any future military conflicts(4). We agree with these general conclusions, and are of the opinion that they apply as well to the question of assessing the political advantages and disadvantages of early combined use. In particular we wish to emphasize that, although we set out below some specific and general comments on the political aspects of the question, the actual political considerations which would bear on any decision would have to be determined according to the circumstances at the time.

8. While confirming the necessity of maintaining a convincing NATO capability to use nuclear weapons as a deterrent, the SHAPE Report points out that, in accordance with its terms of reference, the development of the analysis is confined to assessment factors concerning potential early combined use itself without examining the possible deterrent effect of the threat of an early combined use(5). We observe that a viable and visible NATO capability to resort to early combined use is in itself an inherent threat that a potential aggressor must take into account and should serve, together with other deterrent elements, to dissuade him from initiating an aggression.

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- (1) ACE concepts and doctrine currently governing the employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes are covered in a separate SHAPE Report circulated under cover of NPG/D(73)5, 7th June, 1973
 - (2) SHAPE Report, paragraph 7
 - (3) SHAPE Report, paragraph 14
 - (4) SHAPE Report, paragraph 47
 - (5) SHAPE Report, paragraph 5

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9. On the basis of certain general assumptions and without reference to any specific scenario that might have introduced unnecessary limitations or distortions, the Report discusses a number of inter-related and inter-dependent factors that could have an important influence in determining the extent to which early combined use might be advantageous or disadvantageous from a military point of view: geographical considerations, force deployments, weapon selection and targeting, command and control, military mission, collateral damage and escalation(1). In this context, the Report notes that analysis of these factors is complicated by the probability that, under some circumstances, early combined use would not offer a clear advantage or disadvantage to NATO, but only relatively more advantage or disadvantage than some other feasible military course of action(2). We believe, however, that the SHAPE Report usefully develops in considerable detail the ways in which these separate factors might operate to the military advantage to NATO as well as the ways in which they might work to NATO's disadvantage. Subject to clarifying comments later in this report, we concur with the thrust of the SHAPE analysis. Without detracting from the value of the SHAPE Report, we note in passing that a number of the considerations mentioned in its analysis in connection with assessing relative advantages and disadvantages would be applicable to other nuclear options open to NATO as well as early combined use.

Specific Comments

10. Many of the comments made in the SHAPE analysis are valid from the political point of view as well as from a military standpoint. In the following paragraphs, we focus on some political implications, the analysis of which did not fall within the province of the SHAPE Report.

11. A factor of major political interest, to which the SHAPE Report devotes considerable attention, is escalation. The Report defines escalation as a significant increase in the intensity or magnitude of the combat action, or enlargement of the battle area(3). It is obvious that any first use of nuclear weapons will represent a very serious step in the escalation process. In this context, the Military Committee has pointed out that even small yield nuclear weapons and ADMs introduce a qualitative change in the conflict(4). However, we note that the Report, in examining escalation and its implications in the early combined use context, also introduces

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- (1) SHAPE Report, paragraphs 11-46
 - (2) SHAPE Report, paragraph 14
 - (3) SHAPE Report, paragraph 9c
 - (4) MC Comments, paragraph 5

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such implied aspects as motivation for, or perceptions of, escalation. For example, a number of substantive statements in the Report explore military considerations that would support or inhibit a NATO decision to escalate. The Report also deals with the risk of escalation(1) which includes such aspects as how the enemy might perceive NATO's actions and how he himself might be motivated to escalate.

12. With respect to risks of escalation, we note with particular interest the close relationship reflected in the SHAPE Report between such risks and certain considerations of NATO force deployments(2), collateral damage expectations(3) and some features of weapon selection and targeting(4). In commenting on some of the factors in the SHAPE Report, the Military Committee adds the observation that the main factor affecting the degree of escalation for the enemy might well be the degree of risk he is willing to accept and not necessarily NATO's actions per se(5). Concerning the difficulties in predicting the enemy response to early combined use by NATO, the SHAPE Reports points out that the same uncertainties apply to later use. It goes on to note, however, that the consequences to NATO of an enemy reaction, particularly by nuclear means, could be more disadvantageous for NATO forces under later use circumstances(6). The discussion of escalation and its implications in the SHAPE Report and in the related comments by the Military Committee highlights the complexity of this subject.

13. Regarding collateral damage, early combined use could be politically advantageous if it is instrumental in bringing the conflict to a satisfactory conclusion sooner than would otherwise be the case, because it would avoid the collateral damage risks that would be incurred if the fighting extended over a longer period of time. Even if such use does not immediately stop the aggression, it might still induce the enemy to limit the intensity or geographical scope of his attack and thereby reduce the amount of collateral damage inflicted. On the other hand, if early combined use by NATO causes the enemy to increase the magnitude of the aggression, particularly by responding with nuclear weapons, the risk of collateral damage would also be increased. With respect to geographical considerations, if the exercise of the early combined use option enabled NATO to meet and stop the enemy attack before deep penetrations of NATO territory were made, the achievement of a primary NATO political objective of effective forward defence could be realized. This might be of particular importance in terms of collateral damage if the attack were halted before penetrating densely populated areas.

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- (1) The Report describes escalation risk as the likelihood of an enemy response of equal or greater magnitude (SHAPE Report, paragraph 42).
(2) SHAPE Report, paragraph 45
(3) SHAPE Report, paragraphs 42, 44
(4) SHAPE Report, paragraph 44
(5) MC Comments, paragraph 4
(6) SHAPE Report, paragraph 46

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14. With respect to force deployments, we note that in some circumstances additional forces might have to deploy in forward areas prior to the outbreak of hostilities in order to enable NATO to exercise the early combined use option effectively. While this might provoke pre-emptive action by the enemy, it might also forcefully demonstrate NATO's determination to defend itself. Another possible implication of early forward deployment is the probable requirement for timely political actions, such as alert measure decisions. Concerning weapons selection and targeting, it is clear that, particularly in an early combined use context, it might be politically advantageous, depending on the circumstances at the time, to make a distinction among the individual enemy countries insofar as targeting their forces, installations and territory is concerned, or insofar as the weapon yield is concerned.

15. In connection with command and control, the SHAPE Report stresses the need for a responsive and reliable NATO command and control system, particularly in the context of early combined use, and points out that any appreciable disruption would be to NATO's disadvantage. The Report also notes that some effects of nuclear weapon detonations by NATO, such as electro magnetic pulse, might degrade the Alliance's own communications systems, but that the commander's careful selection and employment of weapons could, to a large degree, limit the amount of degradation(1). We believe that, from a political viewpoint, the preservation of an effective command and control system against disruption resulting from nuclear weapons use is of crucial importance if control of the selective use of nuclear weapons is to be exercised effectively by political authorities or NATO military commanders. Conversely, serious disruption of NATO communications could frustrate the political consultation process as well as interfere significantly with the execution of NATO's military operations. However, in discussing the inter-relationship among the various critical factors, the SHAPE Report, in connection with escalation and the enemy's nuclear delivery systems, mentions that a significant military objective in combat is the destruction of the enemy's command and control system(2). Although such destruction might be of military advantage to NATO in that context, it is not so clear that it would necessarily be of benefit from the political point of view, particularly in the early combined use context. For example, the Provisional Political Guidelines state that the fundamental objective of the tactical use of nuclear weapons and the threat of further escalation is to induce the enemy to make the political decision to cease his attack and withdraw(3).

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- (1) SHAPE Report, paragraphs 31, 36
 - (2) SHAPE Report, paragraphs 42, 44
 - (3) DPC/D(69)58(Revised), paragraph 21

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The question might therefore be raised whether it is to NATO's political advantage to disrupt the enemy's command and control system to the point that a political decision to cease the attack could not be transmitted to his remaining forces in the field.

16. The Military Committee has expressed the view that consideration of associated political factors would be necessary to complete a study of all advantages and disadvantages of early combined use(1). In the preceding paragraphs, we have commented on the political implications of a number of the factors mentioned in the SHAPE Report. There are, however, a number of other considerations having broader political implications that must be taken into account in reaching a decision in time of hostilities about early combined use. These considerations include, for example, the utility of such use in demonstrating NATO resolve; its impact on NATO internal cohesiveness; its relationship to the domestic political situation within member countries; its effect on the range of NATO's political choices; its psychological impact on the populations and governments of neutral and enemy nations; and its effect on NATO civilian and military morale. We are of the opinion that the full implications of these considerations cannot be analysed in advance.

Concluding Remarks

17. In summary, we would stress the point that the SHAPE report, the related Military Committee comments and our commentary in this report are analytical in character and do not purport to prescribe guidelines for decision-making. The fact that we have analysed one particular option within the current NATO strategy - early combined use - does not imply any shift in the nuclear threshold beyond the limits now inherent within the current strategy of flexibility in response, which remains unchanged.

18. From the analysis in the SHAPE Report and the related Military Committee comments, we gain the impression that there are likely to be some military advantages from early combined use that would not be realized under later use circumstances. In each instance there could also be military disadvantages to be taken into account. As noted earlier, a complete assessment of the military advantages and disadvantages, and the resulting balance, can only be made in the light of the particular situation that obtains at the time that early combined use is under active consideration. The same reservation applies to the assessment of the political implications. From the political point of view, the evaluation of advantages and disadvantages is complicated further by the fact that many

(1) MC Comments, paragraph 3

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of the factors to be considered cannot be defined and analyzed in advance of the degree of detail that was achieved in the examination of military factors. Nevertheless, political authorities should make themselves aware of the possible political and military implications of early combined use so as to be ready to deal effectively with a real situation. This should also help NATO to avoid losing by default the opportunity to implement the early combined use option. The importance of effective political consultation machinery is also self-evident.

19. It is clear that NATO's ability to exercise the early combined use option in time of hostilities will depend on the readiness of the existing conventional and nuclear forces, the availability of suitable concepts and doctrine for their employment, and the capability of military commanders to execute plans rapidly for their effective utilization. In this context, our recent examination of concepts and doctrine currently governing the employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes(1) leads us to the conclusion that they are fully responsive to the needs of the early combined use option. We also note, as a related matter, that increased NATO conventional strength would provide NATO with additional conventional options that could in turn reduce the need for NATO to have to consider the tactical employment of nuclear weapons, including the early combined use option.

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS

20. The Ministers may wish to:

- (a) take note of the SHAPE Report and the related MC Comments(2) as well as the comments in this report;
- (b) agree that these documents make a valuable contribution toward providing a better understanding by political authorities when assessing, in an actual crisis, advantages and disadvantages of early combined use, as one of the options open to NATO within the current strategy;
- (c) note that the NATO Military Authorities will continue to plan for the exercise of this option if NATO should elect to do so in time of crisis, and to maintain the necessary military capability to implement the option if directed; and

(1) NPG/D(73)5; NPG/D(73)11, 9th October, 1973

(2) NPG/D(73)8

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- (d) note that the operational concepts and doctrine currently governing employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes(1) are sufficiently broad and flexible to accommodate the early combined use option if NATO should elect to exercise it.

(Signed) Joseph M.A.H. LUNS

(1) NPG/D(73)5

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